

Early Creative Influences of D&D and Restrictions on Player Freedom

By Krys Reyes

The massive cultural influence of *Dungeons & Dragons* (*D&D*) cannot be overstated. Widely considered to be the first, at least commercially available, tabletop role-playing game (TTRPG), *D&D* has in a very real sense become the face of the entire TTRPG genre and set the standard for all future TTRPGs to come. However, its reach is not limited to just TTRPGs, but has extended to games in general, including videogames, with many designers citing *D&D* among their inspirations. Moreover, the game is considered incredibly important to the history of the fantasy genre as a whole, as its particular blend of fantasy tropes and elements arguably brought together the best the genre had to offer at the time.

However, just as *D&D* went on to become a huge hit and inspire works for decades to come, so too was *D&D* heavily inspired by many works that came before it, including tabletop games of the 1960s and a plethora of fantasy literature. Notably, the first edition of *D&D* looks very different from recent editions. While they are not entirely unrecognizable from one another, the game has clearly been heavily revised and iterated upon in the decades since its original publication. An interesting pattern emerges when exploring the evolution of *D&D*. Instead of the rules becoming more defined and robust, the game has instead become increasingly *less* rulebound and restrictive overall. This might seem odd at first for a couple of reasons. The general baseline conception of games might be that they are defined by their systems, rules, and restrictions. So to say that the designers envisioned greater benefit in relaxing the rules might seem counterintuitive. Moreover, for a game that often directly ripped ideas from fantasy literature, a genre largely defined by magic and endless possibilities, it is perhaps slightly unexpected that the early iterations of the game would be *too* restrictive, warranting significant

overhauls at times. The reason for this phenomenon is *D&D*'s fundamental nature as a role-playing game where players act out personalized characters under a system that provides them the freedom to *attempt* anything, and the freedom such a system grants. As it turns out, many of the literary inspirations of *D&D* could not be directly adapted to the new medium without encroaching on this player expression and freedom.

For some preliminary history, *D&D* was originally created and designed by Gary Gygax and Dave Arneson, with the original game first published in 1974 and later reorganized and recodified into the first edition as *Advanced Dungeons & Dragons (AD&D)* in 1977. The game is rooted in miniature wargames, a genre of tabletop game in which players control opposing armies represented by physical models of soldiers, artillery, and vehicles on a model of a battlefield. Specifically, *AD&D* was based on the 1971 game *Chainmail*, a miniature wargame also created by Gygax as a fantasy expansion to a set of rules written by Jeff Perren, a hobby-shop owner in the same wargaming club as Gygax.

Meanwhile, a certain David Wesely, inspired by the 1880 military wargame *Strategos*, developed the game *Braunstein* in the 1960s. Wesely was especially interested in the game's referee system, in which one player would take the designated role of referee to make judgements, working on the principle that players could attempt anything. Notably, this is the basis for what would become the role of game/dungeon master (DM). In 1970, Dave Arneson, who was a member of the same wargaming club as Wesely, as well as a player in Wesely's *Braunstein* games, began a medieval variation of Wesely's *Braunstein* games, in which players control individuals instead of armies. Arneson used "*Chainmail* to handle the combat at first" (Arneson 6). Though he and his player eventually found the system lacking, as it only used one dice to resolve encounters, thus he came up with armor class and hit points (Bub 1). As Arneson

continued to play his new system, set in his custom world *Blackmoor*, he iterated upon it and added such innovations as character classes, experience points, levels, and more. As the game grew in intricacy, Arneson devised scenarios where players would quest for gold, escort caravans, lead armies, and delve into the dungeons.

In 1972, David Arneson met with Gary Gygax and ran a game of *Blackmoor* for him. After the meeting, Gygax began a similar campaign of his own which he called *Greyhawk*. Gygax asked Arneson for a draft of his playing rules, and went on to collaborate over long-distance by way of phone and mail, each running playtests with players from their respective game groups.

Clearly, one can trace *D&D*'s roots to several different designers and wargames of the 1960s and 1970s. However, of particular interest are the respective contributions of Gygax and Arneson and the differences between them. Arneson's contributions to *D&D* account for a great part of the jump from miniature wargames to TTRPGs. They include some of the most fundamental and ubiquitous elements of not only modern *D&D*, but the tabletop genre as a whole, such as the focus on controlling individual characters over entire armies, arguably the concept of having a DM, the basic gameplay loop of questing for loot and growing stronger, and even the use of polyhedral dice.

This is not to say that Arneson's contributions to the game were more important than those of Gygax's, but it is interesting to note that while Arneson arguably incorporated the genre-defining elements of *D&D* and TTRPGs that remain to this day, Gygax's contributions and designs, as will be seen, have been continuously revised, some to the point of obsolescence or being unrecognizable. Why is that?

First, it is important to establish Gygax's inspirations. Luckily, Gygax was incredibly meticulous in cataloguing his inspirations, writing several essays, magazine articles, and internet posts on the topic. Most notable is the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for *AD&D*, where under Appendix N can be found a large list of authors, books, and series that inspired various aspects of the game to varying degrees (*AD&D Dungeon Master's Guide* 224). There are far too many works and individual contributions to detail here, but there are a few cases especially worth investigating.

Likely, one of the first things that comes to mind when thinking of fantasy is magic. In the case of *D&D*, an early version of the game incorporated what would be dubbed the "Vancian Magic System." This magic system of *D&D* was largely ripped from the *Dying Earth* novels by Jack Vance, hence the name. In these books, wizards must memorize spells before being able to cast them. After a spell is cast, it wipes itself from the caster's memory, requiring spellcasters to memorize them once again. When incorporated into *D&D*, wizards had to select which spells to memorize for the day.

As for why Gygax chose this style of magic system over others, he explains that "the 'memorize then fire and forget' principle for casting spells Jack Vance assumed in his fantasy stories seemed perfect to [him] for use by *D&D* magic-users. It required forethought by the player and limited the power of the class all at once" (Q&A with Gary Gygax pg. 819). He also stated that it "seemed a perfect way to balance the mage against other types of characters in the game" (Jack Vance & the *D&D* Game 2). As for systems from other novels, Gygax found them to be unsuitable for the game, broadly categorizing them as way too powerful or ineffective, or otherwise too involved or complex for a player to enjoyably pick up. Jack Vance's magic system, on the other hand, was quick and simple, yet versatile, which Gygax thought practical for a

fantasy dungeon crawling adventure where spells needed to be used on the fly (The Dungeons & Dragons Magic System).

However, while Gygax was quite fond of this system, it was the source of much confusion for many players, as they would often misinterpret the rules surrounding spellcasting. Many players did not initially grasp the idea that spells could be cast only once a day, especially for cases, such as the single spell allotted to level 1 wizards and the usage of spells scrolls, which many players thought they could cast at will endlessly (The Dungeons & Dragons Magic System). Even when players had the rules clarified by other players, it was not uncommon for them to ignore this rule.

These types of confusion were not without their consequences it seems, as the magic system was revised in later editions. In the third edition, the game mechanic of “memorizing spells” was replaced with “preparing spells,” which was the same mechanically but marked a thematic difference, straying from the original vision of such an esoteric magic system. A more significant change in this edition was the introduction of 0th level spells, also called cantrips, which could be cast at-will, reflecting the decision of many early *AD&D* players to allow casting at-will. By the fifth edition, the magic system of *D&D* could only be considered a distant derivative of the Vancian magic system. Wizards still have to prepare spells for the day, but they can cast them as many times as they would like up to a certain number of each spell level per day, marking the shift towards more spontaneous casting.

Similar developments occur with several other of the early version mechanics of *D&D*. Take for instance the various player classes. Gygax was heavily inspired by specific characters from the canon of fantasy literature and directly based many of the classes on said characters, idiosyncrasies and all. For example, the barbarian class was heavily inspired by Robert E.

Howard's "Conan the Barbarian," who is deeply suspicious of magic. In turn, the barbarians in *D&D* "detest magic and distrust those who use it" with magic items becoming available to the class only at higher levels (The Big, Bad Barbarian 9). This restriction has since been removed in more recent editions. Though, to this day, the class still retains the character's keen sense for danger in the aptly named skill, *Danger Sense*. Other classes were more generally inspired by specific archetypes but have similar idiosyncrasies nonetheless. For instance, the Paladin class was, in part, inspired by Arthurian legend and similar legends of the paladins of Charlemagne (Q&A with Gary Gygax pg. 41). As such, paladins in the *AD&D* are *required* by the rules to carry themselves as upstanding knights in shining armor. Again, this restriction has largely been removed in recent editions.

The emerging pattern here is that Gygax made many of the rules overly restrictive for player characters. Certain races and classes were *required* by the rules to role-play in a particular way. Certain features, like specific items or languages, were similarly cut off from certain races and classes. Many game mechanics, most notably the magic system, were far too limited as a resource, leading to players often ignoring particular rules on magic. However, it is not that these elements taken from fantasy literature were completely incompatible with *D&D*, as iterations of these mechanics still exist in current editions. Rather, Gygax did not allow for much deviation from the works he ripped from and, arguably, did not properly adapt them to the game medium. A player could not just play a barbarian, they had to play a *Conan* style barbarian, suspicious of magic. A player could not just play a Paladin, they had to play a knight in shining armor. A wizard could not just start casting cool spells, they had to follow the very odd and esoteric set of rules.

Indeed, Gygas and Arneson seemingly had opposite approaches. On the matter of the origins of *Blackmoor*, Arneson even mentions that “[he] was also quite tired of [his] [Napoleonic] campaign with all its rigid rules, etc, and was perhaps rebelling against it” (My Life and Role-Playing 6). On the other hand, Gygas, who hailed from the world of miniature wargames, primarily built on top of Arneson's system by ripping ideas from fantasy literature and incorporating them as streamlined hard mechanics. However, one comes to realize that Gygas was heavily biased, not only towards specific fantasy works he liked, but towards a very specific style of play. As such, many of the mechanics that he ripped from fantasy literature were given less leeway for players than would be expected. And as it turns out, this would not be tolerated for long.

In the decades since, more recent editions of *D&D* have loosened restrictions on class, race, and alignment, and the game has become less focused on the resource management aspects. On the other hand, many players would argue that the contemporary designers overcompensated, claiming with class and race choices now largely inconsequential and mostly for aesthetics. Certainly, it is a tricky thing to create a robust system of rules without encroaching on player options. Conversely, it is tricky to strive for player freedom without going overboard and the whole thing turning into a structureless mess. However, with *D&D* strongly persisting after more than half a century, there is likely more work on the horizon.

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